- **Diabetes:** Diabetes makes arteries less elastic, which may increase the workload for the heart. Therefore, diabetics develop hypertension because of the effect of diabetes on the blood vessels.
- **Alcohol:** Excess alcohol intake could cause a rise in blood pressure and also increase the risk of stroke.
- **Dietary Factors :**

1. Increased intake of energy has been associated with an increase in blood pressure.
2. Higher intakes of cholesterol and saturated fat are associated with elevated blood pressure levels.
3. A high-fibre diet that includes a liberal intake of greens and vegetables causes a significant reduction in blood pressure levels of hypertensive individuals.
4. High intake of sodium is directly linked with hypertension.
5. Dietary calcium and magnesium intake have been related to lower blood pressure.
6. Caffeine present in coffee can produce a short term significant increase in blood pressure.



Salt is sodium chloride. Sodium makes up 40% of sodium chloride. One gram of salt contains 400 milligrams sodium. Now we can calculate the sodium content in varying quantities of salt

Salt in grams	Spoon Measurement	Sodium in milligrams
1	A pinch of salt	400
1.25	¼ tsp salt	500
2.5	½ tsp salt	1000
5	1 tsp salt	2000
10	2 tsp salt	4000

11.3 Symptoms and complications of hypertension

Common symptoms observed in hypertension are the following:

- Headache
- Dizziness
- Impaired vision
- Irregular heart beat
- Fatigue
- Failing memory
- Confusion
- Shortness of breath
- Gastrointestinal disturbances
- Anxiety
- Bleeding from nose
- Excess sweating
- Tinnitus or ringing in the ears

The extent of symptoms depends on the elevation of the blood pressure and the duration of time it has been present. Untreated high blood pressure can lead to heart attack, stroke, heart failure, kidney damage, fluid build-up in the lungs and memory loss.

11.4 Sodium intake and hypertension

A high intake of table salt is considered to be a causative factor for hypertension. **Salt is sodium chloride** where sodium makes up 40 percent of the sodium chloride. Both sodium and chloride are essential for maintaining fluid and electrolyte balance and thus blood pressure. This balance gets disturbed when the salt intake is excessive leading to fluid collection in tissues of the body especially that of the feet and hands. This condition is called **"oedema".** A sodium-restricted diet is recommended to alleviate this condition. When the sodium content in the diet is reduced, the water and salts in the tissues flow back into the blood to be excreted by the kidneys. Thereby, oedema is relieved.

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